

Malls of the Future

New technologies such as augmented reality, Near Field Communication, smart shopping devices and SixthSense technology are facilitating emergence of highly interactive customer touchpoints. These technologies are developing at an astonishing pace, throwing complex challenges for retailers. While some touchpoints have been adopted, many are still in the pilot stage. Here is a brief overview



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You are walking through a swanky shopping mall and you notice an interactive advertising wall with QR codes displaying several latest woolen jacket designs. It is beginning to get colder and you realise that you need a warm jacket. As you walk into your favourite apparel retail store, the thermal crowd management non-intrusive sensor installed at its entrance door detects your body heat, records your entry and adds you as a customer into the system.

You go to the shelf where the jackets are displayed and tell the store executive that you would like to try all the six designs. He notes down the product codes of the jackets and leads you to

a high-tech mirror. The mirror's parametric technology simulates your body type based on your weight, height and measurements and one by one shows how you would look in each jacket. After this, it simultaneously shows you all your pictures in each of the six jackets so that you can compare and finally decide which one to buy.

After paying for the jacket, you briefly stop at a music and movies store. The latest Bond film is available but you have not read its reviews yet. You decide to judge it for yourself. So you hold your mobile phone over the DVD's bar code and the Bond flick's trailer starts playing on your phone's screen.

This is not a scene out of some sci-fi movie, but something you can look

forward to experiencing in the near future.

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Smart shopping technology and devices

Smart carts. IBM, NCR, Fujitsu and Hewlett-Packard are developing smart shopping devices that are likely to be widely used in the near future. Work is underway on a supermarket smart cart that has a screen embedded in its handles. A shopper needs to swipe a smart card through a slot in the cart to trigger the device 'on.'

The screen communicates with the customer, notifying him of various in-store offers and promotions. The cart keeps track of all the products kept in



Fig. 1: A smart shopping cart